

JOBS **The Great Quota Race**

| By Shyamlal Yadav |

Promise is the primary instrument of political evangelism. More so in India. Shorn of ideas and pretence, regional political dynasties pushed a pusillanimous regime to surrender and include caste in Census 2011. While one-caste parties are projecting this as Aladdin's lamp that will deliver goodies, in effect it is the opening up of a Pandora's box once again after the late 1980s. The issue, fraught with complex conflicts and contradictions, promises to trigger another round of virulent political agitation and litigation.

The politics of job quotas is embedded in India's peculiar economics. Seven of 10 people in India are dependent on agriculture which accounts for barely a fifth of the national income. Worse, the proportion of those working in the unorganised and organised sector is lopsided with barely seven Indians in the working age population holding a job in the organised sector. And thanks to rigid labour laws, most of these are in the public sector. According to the Ministry of Labour and Employment, of the 2.72 crore people in the organised sector, 1.8 crore are employed in the public sector. Given this low availability of secure jobs, employment quotas have naturally acquired premium status and worth in the political battleground.

As of now, 27 per cent of government jobs are reserved for the OBCs as recommended by the Mandal Commission Report in 1980 and implemented since 1993 following a Supreme Court ruling. This limit is based on a disaggregation of caste conducted in the census of 1931. Since then, there has been no OBC enumeration although there have been sample surveys conducted by the NSSO. According to the National Family Health Survey conducted in 2005-06, the estimated population of OBC households in the country was 39.6 per cent. Given the co-relation between backwardness and growth rate, this ratio is bound to shoot up. And this is what the political class is betting on. Says Sharad Yadav, the NDA convenor, who was at the forefront with Mulayam Singh Yadav and Lalu Prasad Yadav in demanding a caste-based census, "Whatever be the result, the truth must come out. *Doodh ka doodh aur paani ka paani.*"

A higher proportion of OBCs in the population or SCs (fuelled by the downward migration of castes) will trigger demands for raising the cap. Arguing for its case in the Lok Sabha, Sharad thundered, "In 20 ministries and 18 departments, there is not a single OBC in the Group A category." Others point out how OBCs account for barely 10 per cent of IAS officers despite the fact they are estimated at 52 per cent of the population. Worse, there is a growing perception that even this has been cornered by the dominant groups within the OBCs, like the Yadavs, Kurmis and Lodhs in Uttar Pradesh and the Yadavs, Kurmis and Koiris in Bihar. Indeed Udit Raj, the bureaucrat-turned-politician battling for the Dalit cause, says, "This caste-based enumeration may boomerang on the present established leadership of OBCs."

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